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PREFACE: WORKING NOTES ON SOCIAL RELATIONS IN COMMUNICATION AND CULTURE

THE POPULAR

One of the most "popular" misconceptions is the "popular" conception of the popular.

Its linguistic origins and definition in English evolves from a late Medieval meaning "of the people", to its current ruling definition "regarded with favour or affection by most persons",[1] a conceptual evolution corresponding rather closely to the evolution of civil society.

With the rise of bourgeois democracies, and their claim to a legitimacy based on popular sovereignty, today expressed politically in the electoral process (although even this is increasingly threatened, both actively and especially passively, in practice) has come a veritable mythology of a certain idea of the popular, as a stamp of approval for ruling actions and programs, including that of the TV. Needless to say, however, this certain idea of the popular does not rule alone, and is continually changing and is occasionally threatened by popular uprisings, both military as well as cultural.

From the political sphere the dominant use of the popular has spread out to the cultural sphere, reinforcing an idea of the popular by carrying it into new areas, giving it new forms of expression, and a new supporting role for the social system, as exemplified today by the "popular" TV program, "popular" film star, or more generally, "popular" or "pop" culture.

This certain idea of the popular is also the underlying justification hiding behind the concept of "public opinion". Not surprisingly, the latter's history, too, has moved from an active, productive process in support of the bourgeoisie's ascendency to a passive "silent majority", negative, consumption-oriented support today. In its economic sense, it is the history of an open active marketplace of multiple small producers/citizens — at least for propertied white men — and its evolution to a closed monopolized marketplace, and the crisis engendered by this transition.

The confusion maintained around the idea of the popular, between "of the people" and that which is "regard [ed] with favor or affection by most persons", is not just due to an innocent misunderstanding or the complex overlay of ideas connected to the movement of past history. It is especially useful today to connect the "people" to a certain idea of the cultural, social and political; to a certain idea of people's opinion and consciousness; and ultimately, to a certain idea of what people were, are, can or will be.

Nowhere is this ambiguity more profitable for the ruling forces than in its promotion of the notion of the "popular" TV program, "popular" bestseller, etc., a denomination which is often taken for granted by people who should be more critical. Behind this idea is lurking a veritable network of related sub-ideas, sub-confusions, sub-myths, of more or less importance.

For example. If we are told that statistically, 30% of a public is said to watch a certain TV program, does this necessarily mean that it is "popular", either in the sense "of the people" or even that 30% of the people approve of it? Nothing is less clear or more conditional or misleading, although this type of logic is reinforced by a very strong prevailing "common sense" functionalist strain, "popular(?)" even on the Left. If, for example, 60% of a population goes to work 40 hours a week, or 75% of the population lives in urban centers, or 90% of the population lives to 70 years of age, does this mean that their work, of the city, or their lifespan is "popular", that they all "approve" of their work, or the city, or — why not? — their death? In other words, does "many", "most" persons, even "majority" equal "popular"? Or expressed more politically, does the advance of a society necessarily (or still), express itself only through the consensus of a majority?

Why is it that in the second series of examples concerning work, the city, or the human lifespan, the notion of the "popular" hardly appears, and a necessity appears to reign in which people are given little or no latitude to express themselves? Why on the other hand, with a TV program, TV watching in general or simply, entertainment and leisure — in short, consumption — are people today supposed to have a freedom permitting them to express some "profound" "popular" social-cultural essense, desire or sensibility? Why is it that the "cultural" sphere, especially as conceived as an industrialized sphere of non-work, leisure-time consumption, is today put forth as a — the — prime model for social liberty, or at least, a certain idea of liberty? Does not this one-sided emphasis tend to hide the present lack of choice and creativity to be found in the other spheres of economic and social life, thus preventing the possibility of examining and then pushing forward new freedoms in these other areas? Is the supermarket really to be the model for social life? This capitalist image is very very strong, and is often symbolically used to pit the colorful "plurality" of capitalism against the grey uniformity or lack thereof in the so-called "socialist" and "third" worlds. Are there not very real social parameters also conditioning cultural life, even as consumption, TV watching in general, and even to a lesser

1. *The Random House Dictionary of the English Language (College Edition)*, New York, Random House, 1968. See also their definition of "popular song", for example: "a song written for its immediate commercial potential, intended for widespread dissemination through recording, broadcasts, etc." Note the not-so-subtle connection made between the "popular song" and commercial potential.

degree, a given TV program?

Here we are thinking of general, but nevertheless, real determinants such as education level; available physical, intellectual or creative energy after a hard, or especially today, a boring or alienated day's work; the non-availability or high cost of other possible activities (including the increasing cost of public and private transport, etc.); the apparent low-cost and ease of TV-watching or browsing; plus, subjective parameters, especially, the insecurity maintained in the public spaces and the security of the closed home, further accentuated by much of today's "technological advances", and the current crisis and its related ideas.

And in addition, concering the viewing of a specific program, especially the series,[2] does not habit, routine, often unconscious, play a very important role? (This would appear to be an important pre-condition for the successful reception of capitalist cultural merchandise.) What about the interlocking promotion of certain shows and personalities by other media, and *vice-versa*; the press, books, radio, organized gossip, tee-shirts and other "spin-offs", etc. Are not all of these factors ways to virtually pressure — force — people to watch or do certain things and not other things? Is not this type of "freedom" of choice getting very very close to a form of necessity we are given to believe exists only in the other domains, among others, mentioned earlier? Especially since today these forces are no longer left to "chance", as in earlier times, and are increasingly organized. All these factors, before we even approach the question of audience reception; the different ways in which TV is received and perceived by different classes, sectors, strata, groups and individuals.

What does the popular mean today in the context of these increasingly organized, controlled, manipulated, and especially, generalized, realities?

In light of these "mass"-produced authoritarian pressures, is it still possible to distinguish an autonomous popular character of the subaltern classes from that of the ruling classes; a character which at one time appeared directly linked to the subsistance level of subaltern material life? If not, why not?, and what does this perhaps tell us about present relations between rulers and ruled in the domains of ideology, culture and communications?

How have these relations evolved and how are they presently evolving, at least here in the so-called "advanced" capitalist countries? How are these relations today linked to economic exploitation? Are there any parallels in the spheres of ideology, culture or communication concerning the classic, growing contradiction between the forces of production and the relations of production? And lastly, if it is possible to specify the popular in cultural as well as in political and economic life, and its expression in different social formations and periods, is it then possible to draw any theoretical conclusion from this information, to say nothing of formulating a strategy for future action?

In considering very briefly some of these problems it is not a matter of preparing a catalogue of eternally-fixed, specific progressive, socially-advanced, etc. properties inherent in popular life. It would be a very false confrontation to oppose ruling conservative functionalist myths and images with subaltern, Left, even dialectic ones. Rather our purpose is to try to outline some experiences and tendencies in the history of the oppressed classes, stratum, groups, and — why not? — even individuals, and how in their resistance to exploitation and search for liberation, their creativity has manifested, and is manifesting, itself in the areas of culture and communication. It is this search which is the principle underlying the production of this second volume of *Communication and Class Struggle*.

CULTURE

Before trying to outline the problems posed by today's specific network of interlocking and conflicting interests of the rulers and ruled in the domains of culture and communication, and to try to distinguish today's "mass" culture as a specific form of ruling, general and generalisible, prefabricated, ready-to-wear culture made to adhere to the changing contours of monopoly capitalism, from a concrete, made-to-order popular culture, it is vital to first try to define, if only very broadly, what is meant by "culture".

Although its definition is often limited to the higher, special, ethereal realms of human experience, it should be, on the contrary, a basic, all-embracing concept permeating all aspects of life, as it is perhaps the most fundamental element unique to each different peoples, societies, classes, stratum, and groups. As such, perhaps culture can best be defined as the specific "way" a historically-determined group or class creates, reproduces and develops its material and social existence. A "way" to create which underlies not only a certain type and form of material production, but especially the

2. The industrialization and generalization of the series form is perhaps one of the prime(-time) characteristics of mass culture today. Being based on the mass production, multiplication, and manipulation of a (hopefully) successful formula, gimmick, or personality-trademark, it is increasingly taking over till industrial cultural production (as in the Second, Third, etc. editions of a film, like Superman II, Rocky III, etc.), but also books, etc. This includes so-called "remakes" of often old successful films, books, and especially mass music, the effect of which is to limit "original" new production, even other junky, mass-market stuff. This series production, a mass-cultural form of aesthetic long-term planning, is intended to be economically less risky, being dependent on "already'-known" elements, but it absolutely depends on the social development of unconscious *habit* and especially the *security* of knowing what will happen next. (Like the "reason", usually completely irrational, for smoking one cigarette and not another.) This is in contrast with the nineteenth-century serial novels, for example, where excitement and unknown adventure around a successful personality were the order of the day. This series production strategy is also — coincidently? — in very sharp contrast with contemporary reality, especially on the world scale, which is increasingly full of surprises, apparently sudden, unexpected developments, alliances, and conflicts and contradictions, etc. Perhaps the series are just another way to calm the spirits, the nerves, a form of "pain-killer" or tranquilizer.

production of a certain (evolving) set of conscious, but also unconscious, beliefs, values, ideas, feelings, corporal gestures, daily life habits, languages, communications, etc., which together compose a given culture: in short, a way of life, a way of doing things; in a sense, also an aesthetic or creative dimension; a way a given society "looks", "feels", its "sensibility"; a sort of social personality.

Historically, this "way of doing things" was first closely conditioned by the external natural environment, but with the passage of time it has become more and more linked to the "internal" man-and-woman-made social environment, and thus subject, if only potentially, to their will and control.

Although culture is often spoken of as a "collective" phenomenon this can be misleading, as it hides its heterogenous character, the fact that it is neither uniformly nor equally created or shared by everyone, all groups, all classes. Rather it should perhaps be understood more like the *resultant* of the ways of life of all its constituent groups, classes and individuals, in their overall relations of force, internally, and externally, their contact with other societies, other resultant ways of life in their relations of force.

A culture is rarely conceived of as a resultant of forces, especially, here, of creative forces. Often it is either taken for granted, especially by the rulers, and claimed as being the only culture, or more recently, by the ruled, as being the dominant, or most recently, the hegemonic, culture. In the first case, it is the very existence, the very personality, of the subaltern classes' way of life which is repressed or hidden, while in the second or even the third, it is often the interrelationships between the ruling and subaltern cultures which is ignored or minimized: two cultures which are often conceived of as separate, and autonomous, turning around a common reality, whose relations are often reduced to the articulation and mediation of intellectuals. But perhaps isn't it precisely here that we should also look for the particular meeting between the communication and cultural processes?

Unlike today, in earlier, pre-capitalist social formations, the constituent components of a resultant culture, the ways of life of its ruling and ruled classes and sectors appear more obviously, directly and immediately linked to their respective material conditions of life, conditions which differed greatly between rulers and ruled. Whereas there appears to have been, on the one hand, a strong, less-contested, ruling predominance in the "production" of ideas, on the other hand, the actual production of material "ways of life" was sharply differentiated by both the quantity and quality (and often, rarity) of the materiality, and especially, the quality and quantity of the labor needed to work this materiality.

Thus, popular objects, except for the rare ceremonial, etc., can be characterized by their utility. Linked to daily existence, with a poverty of media, base materials, they have a high level of use value, whereas objects destined for rulers tend in the other direction, towards occasional, sparing, ritualistic use, often made of rare, costly materials (and labor) expressly for their economic, and exchange value. Needless to say, it is this type of production which has been valued, saved, protected, preserved and inventoried, etc, and thus forms the dominant background to our appreciation of popular creation, although since the late nineteenth century and the disappearance of the conditions of production of popular objects, these too have begun to be the object of intellectual as well as economic speculation, and prized as collector's items.

This differentiation between the ruling and subaltern "way of doing things", or perhaps more precisely in the case of the former, a "way of not doing things", can also be expressed as the relation between the head/hand, the idea/execution, etc., still a very central element in the expropriation and exploitation process.[3]

Thus, there is a very important difference between the (class) production of ideology and that of a material culture. In ideology, each and every class or group, from dominant to subaltern, struggles to develop its own ideas, and system of ideas, to maintain, to define, to specify, to explain, to protect, to justify, to extend, etc. its real or imagined interests in relationship to a given level of material existense and its evolution. In material production, however, there is no struggle as such, as concrete material creation has always been in the hands — both figuratively and literally — of the exploited classes, who create both for "itself" and for "others". So while rulers expropriate, appropriate, direct, manipulate, control, influence, etc., this should not be confused with material production itself, especially its creative aspect.

Thus social development in its fullest sense takes place essentially through the development and liberation of the exploited working sectors, as it is only they who can possibly unite the creation of the material, which is their traditional "historic" role, with a possible development of the ideological, the social, the political. In brief, social advancement as being the (re-?) unification and mastery of theory and practice, of the mind and the hand.

This long contradictory history of the production of a material culture — sometimes called folklore, or more recently, cultural anthropology—, behind the collection of its artefacts, is essentially the history of the generalized development of the "personality", sensibilities and creativity of the worker, as his or her personality has lived and produced under successive modes of exploitation:

—from primitive domestic crafts destined for immediate family or tribal or clan use;

—through the rise of a surplus, barter and exchange, and the rise of craft production and the ancient anonymous, though very real, artisan-craftsman/woman present throughout society, a form of creativity whose individually is subsumed under collective values, wherein all the products of a culture are marked by a strong unifying collective style, in a ruling world where individual life, especially the

3. For a detailed analysis of this head/hand relationship on a world capitalist scale, between the so-called "developed" and "under-developed" worlds, see Ariel Dorfman's and Armand Mattelart's *How To Read Donald Duck*, New York, International General, 1975.

popular, itself, had little value;

—through the breakdown of agricultural, slave, nomad and peasant life and the rise of late feudalism and early capitalism, with the contradictory rise, on the one hand, of some, often-puiviileged individual artists, the rise of a specialized "Fine" art divorced from "practical" life, in which "collective" values gradually gives way to "signed", ever-more personal styles, etc, while on the other hand, for the mass of workers, the studio, then the factory, slowly destroys the "unified" individual craftsman/woman, the guild, by re-organizing and imposing new forms of creative labor increasingly under the direct rule of capital;

—to the rise of nineteenth-century capitalism and the rise of a new, unique form of dominant culture, "mass" culture, characterized by its emergence as a specialized economic sector and its ever increasing industrial fabrication; and most important, the fact that it is the first culture expressly made for and directed towards the mobilized popular and working classes.

COMMUNICATION

Communication = exchange. Its development, the multiplication of its forms are the foundation and signs, products and producers, of both collective and individual development. The increase in the quantity and especially, the quality, of these exchanges is at the heart of the advancement of society, one of the principal marks of social progress, the basis of true liberation, whether national, regional, local or individual. (Here, however, we are facing a fundamental problem as this multiplication takes place essentially in direct proportion to the division of labor, one of the main alienating obstacles to be overcome in any process of liberation.)

One of the most evident characteristics of this communication is its instrumentality, its location in the social process as a physical link between time and space; as a social relation between people. However, as an instrument, as a means, a thing — a road, a boat, a sheet of paper, a newspaper, a pipeline, an electric wire, a broadcast frequency, etc. — it is by definition incomplete by itself. In a certain sense, it is lacking a finality, an end, a product, a content, which can be called information, as used in the sense of knowledge, scientific, social or otherwise, or more generally, culture, a way of life. (Needless to say, there is an intimate connection between a given type or form of communication and a given type of information or culture, insofar as it itself is also a product of a certain culture, also partaking of a particular way of life, with its common "look", "feel", and sensibility.)

This material, instrumental aspect is clearly given much visibility and importance, as it appears to be the direct and immediate object of social-political struggles. In addition, it is given further weight by the ruling forces as its success and influence is important evidence reinforcing their power and supremacy. Needless to say, this material presense and its growth — quantitative iff not qualitative — like other sectors, are among the motor forces acting behind the ruling classes' idea of progress. These ideas of progress, however, are increasingly contested, both by their own rules of functionning, and their crisis, as well as by subaltern forces.

Another, more "political" way to look at the history of communication is as a social practice, to treat it as the simultaneous history of (a) the exchanges between different classes, groups, peoples, etc, ie, inter-relations, and (b) the exchanges between the members of a given class or group, ie, intra-relations, during a given historical period. It may even be possible to better understand an epoch by appreciating the specific configurations made by the interaction of these different types of communication.

Before the rise of the capitalist epoch, there appears to be a relatively large separation between rulers and ruled, wide communication gaps, large spaces, physical, social, cultural and psychological, where the ruling way of life did not — or could not or did not need to — penetrate or communicate with subaltern life, and, *vice-versa*. On the one hand, political-military, authoritarian domination was absolute: the right to work, the right to speak, etc., often including the very control over life itself; on the other hand, it was separate and limited in time and space to certain areas. This was perhaps because, exploitation itself was "limited", for the most part, to the expropriation of existing small-scale production, agricultural and artisan craft or guild production via levees, taxes, rents, tributes, etc., not to the organization and nature of this production. Each person, or more exactly, each type of person, had their place in the ruling order of things. Despite the diffused powerful ideological cement represented by religion and later the church, which itself eventually broke down into "high" and "low", there was relatively little ruling interest in the "lower orders" beyond their direct utility in the production process. Politically, their vote was not needed; economically their so-called "purchasing power" was not needed; in short, there was no need to "convince" them of anything, force or the threat thereof was enough.

This has evolved considerably. Today, after long centuries of struggle, ruling domination has been eaten away and is no longer absolute — in fact, it is more and more contested — but via the State and without, has penetrated and diffused itself within and throughout practically all areas of social life, within production and elsewhere, as it now itself directly organizes exploitation and its (now) large-scale production (though taxes and rents still continue). This insinuation of a ruling "mass" culture, leaving smaller and smaller, fewer and fewer areas untouched or autonomous, however, has also brought with it a very contradictory process of resistance and liberation, a process which is increasingly opening up new, often unsuspected fronts of emancipation, both geographically and socially, and with it a profound questioning of all aspects of inter- and intra- class and group relations.

However, there is perhaps a third, more important profound sense to communication. If the means of communication-as-instrument corresponds to an "economic" view of the material, tangible, visible infrastructure of a social formation, that part of a

recent quantitative struggle within the expanding limits of capitalist production and reproduction for the collective freedoms of assembly, universal suffrage, humane work conditions, a basic education, health care; or today, with the increased variety of struggles, the right to a difference, to a specificity, to a "personality", whether national, regional, local or individual, with all the possible political ambiguities and risks this implies: a complete rethinking of the relationship of the one to the many, the individual to the collectivity, the specific to the general.

The traditional progressive, even revolutionary political parties, which at the turn of the century were built on the urban working class, today appear incapable of understanding, or in many cases, even just expressing, these new aspirations, new political struggles, possible new forms of intra-class relations, either in their internal or external relations.

One of the reasons is that the working class has changed fundamentally, as capital and its exploitation process has penetrated and diffused itself throughout economic, social and cultural life, intensifying more and more areas of new or latent conflicts, and with it, provoking new protagonists. In the process, the classic industrial workplace has now become only one of many areas of struggle, through perhaps still more important than others, sometimes in the vanguard, sometimes rearguard, sometimes more intense, sometimes less intense. This shift of emphasis is also due to the growing awareness that, at the present moment at least, the "mass" production work process, with its parcellization, brutalization, alienation, hierarchies, etc. — and not just its form under capitalism — promises little possibility for individual creative development, or even collective creative experience. Thus today, it appears that much popular creative energy is now re-directed and expressed outside the factory, contributing thus to the further opening-up of new areas of personal expression, of possible liberation.

The generalization of this search for new forms of popular creativity, and new possibilities of individual and collective expression, enrichment and liberation, in many respects, is often at odds with certain prevailing Left political practices and ideas which arose during the formative period of industrial capitalism. This was a historical period with a certain level of economic development/poverty; a certain frequency, intensity and type of intra- and especially inter-class exchanges, often brutal; a certain level of critical consciousness and mobilization, etc. contributing to the formation of a particular type of political organization, practices and ideas, characterized, for example, by

— an enlightened vanguard "leading" the "backward" masses;

— a form of centralized, almost military, political organization in which discipline was a key element, in a strategy based in large part on the need for a rapid, unified response to the class enemy;

— an ideological struggle based on a concept of propaganda and agitation whose purpose was "mobilizing" people around a series of specific demands;

— a concept of culture as being almost synonomous with the uplifting, and the education, of the masses;

— a concentration of struggle centered economically, almost exclusively on the exploitation in the workplace, especially the large-scale factory; and politically, on the taking of a bourgeois State which would then be transformed to "do" things, liberate, etc., the popular classes;

— a system of political representation which tended in practice, perhaps by virtue of the prevailing type of class confrontation, to reduce the variety of the popular forces to the working class, which then became the urban proletariat, then the proletarian avant-garde, then the Party, then the Central Committee, then the Political Bureau, and ultimately, the General Secretary;

— an organization emphasizing more the distribution of ideas (often produced by a limited number of people), rather than its production by the many;

— a concept of social progress in which "good" collective interests and values would eventually overwhelm "selfish" individual interests and values;

in short, a historically-defined project of liberation, which despite its often heroic character, in practice tended to be constructed from the "top" to "bottom", from center to periphery, from the one to the many.

If, in the so-called "advanced" capitalist countries we are now living another, higher reality, thanks in part to these former struggles but also to the development of the productive forces, a reality which is calling in many voices for another project of liberation, this new project is still far from being articulated. Articulated in its double sense: that of its theoretical expression, and particularly, in the sense of the development of new types of relationships, new forms of communication linking and corresponding to a variety of conscious actors, who, each in their way, will all be needed if we are ever to construct from the "bottom up" a truly liberation person, a society free from all forms of exploitation.

It is hoped that this book, in some small way, will contribute to a better understanding of the historical dimension of this striving for liberation, and some aspects and possibilities in its contemporary expression.